

Exits in the UK: IPOs and Acquisitions 2013–H1 2023



In collaboration with Charles Stanley, we explore the acquisitions and IPOs completed by high-growth UK companies over the past decade.

Since 2013, 5,899 companies have exited the UK's high-growth ecosystem via an acquisition or an initial public offering (IPO). In spite of the macroeconomic uncertainties surrounding inflation and rising interest rates in 2022, the exit market demonstrated relative strength compared to the highs seen in 2021. The figures for the first half of 2023 indicate a reversion to pre-pandemic norms amidst challenging economic conditions. However, the complete picture will emerge with the figures for the latter half of 2023.

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Inside the report

Market overview

The market for equity in private UK companies was buoyed by affordable capital and increased risk appetite following stimulus measures introduced to combat the COVID-19 pandemic. Exits for established high-growth companies (those with turnover measured in the 10s of millions) more than doubled between 2020 and 2021. Exits by growth businesses (those with revenues measured in the millions) saw a similar trajectory. Part of the story is the depressed exit activity during 2020 as trade and financial buyers adjusted to the new reality of a locked-down world.

Although exits in 2022 fell a little short of the highs of 2021, the market for equity in private UK businesses was still strong despite inflation and rising interest rates. Deals in the first half will have been driven by the momentum of 2021. While in the second half, the depressed pound kept some opportunistic buyers on the front foot. The H1 2023 figures suggest a return to pre-pandemic norms, though against a challenging backdrop. The H2 2023 figures will tell the full story in the Charles Stanley Fortune Favours survey. 27% of entrepreneurs indicated that rising interest rates had caused them to alter succession plans or their exit strategy.

Key figures (2013-H1 2023)

5,899

number of exits by high-growth companies

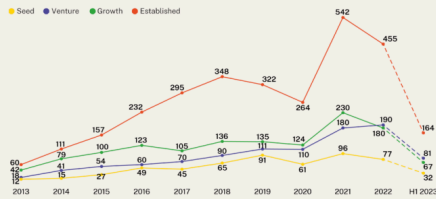
3.71%

proportion of exits that were IPOs

96.3%

proportion of exits that were acquisitions

Exits by UK high-growth companies by stage of evolution (2013-H1 2023)



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Secondary transaction trends

Key figures (2014-H1 2023)

6,663

companies that have completed founder secondaries

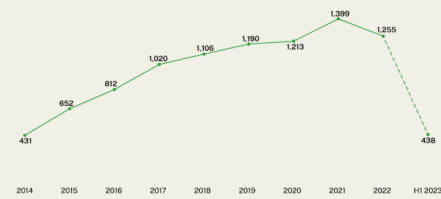
9,723

number of founder secondaries by equity-backed companies

291%

percentage increase in companies completing founder secondaries

Number of equity-backed companies completing founder secondary transactions (2014-H1 2023)



A secondary transaction is the sale of existing shares in a company by a current shareholder to a new party, without the issuance of new shares by the company. The funds go to the selling shareholder, allowing them to realise some of the value of their equity in the company. This analysis is focused on secondary transactions by founders who are shareholders.

The number of equity-backed companies engaging in founder secondary transactions has increased significantly, rising from 431 in 2014 to a peak of 1,399 in 2021. This growth partially reflects the growing number of equity-

backed businesses in the UK and underscores the nation's maturing entrepreneurial ecosystem. In 2014, 3.45% of the active high-growth companies had some secondary activity, while 2021 saw a peak with 5.84% of companies completing a founder secondary.

These figures are derived from annual confirmation statements filed with Companies House, which provide a snapshot of a company's shareholder information. This results in an inherent time lag in this data and means these snapshots may not capture interim changes to shareholdings between filings.

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and high-growth businesses. He worked on briefs for the likes of Barclays, SyndicateRoom, Innovate UK, Smith & Williamson and British Business Bank. He regularly gives presentations on market trends at events around the UK.

consultancy team. He has a background in business analysis and commercial copywriting in Australia and the UK, having worked at The Sunday Times Fast Track, Oxford University Press, and advertising network MullenLowe Group.

consultancy team. She has worked on projects for clients including Barclays, EY and JP Morgan. Freya holds a BA in History (International) from the University of Leeds, which included a year at Fudan University in Shanghai.



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Advone writes copy, and performs data analysis and visualisation. She has written on the nature of Venture Capital Trusts, and worked on projects for Rawnet and



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Ethan carries out data analysis and visualisation. Before joining Beauhurst, Ethan graduated from the University of Bath, where he was awarded the degree of

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